no small measure of sympathy for whoever was doing the simultaneous translation.

The only discordant note came from Moshe Kahlon, the finance minister. “A threat is a threat,” he said, noting that his office was prepared to help Israeli businesses hurt by boycotts. But he went on to explain that he hadn’t received many phone calls. “I don’t think there’s something that you can specifically call a detrimental effect, or some kind of damage” to the economy, he said.

BDS activists are much better at self-promotion than they are at causing economic pain. A decade after the campaign started, it has had almost no discernible impact. Foreign investments in Israel hit a record high of $285 billion in 2015, a threefold increase since the BDS movement started. Exports to the European Union, its largest trading partner, were up more than 30 per cent during that period. Western embassies host never-ending delegations of business executives, eager to talk high-tech in Tel Aviv and agriculture in the Negev. And Israel’s emerging allies in Asia and Africa literally laugh when asked about pressure from the BDS campaign. “We view it as a fad on your college campuses,” one Asian diplomat in Tel Aviv told me.

The movement insists otherwise. It has a long list of “successes” on its website. Yet it can rarely prove that these victories resulted from political pressure and not ordinary market forces. One of the prime BDS targets is Alstom, a French conglomerate that helped to build the Jerusalem light rail, which cuts through the occupied eastern half of the city. The campaign demanded that it withdraw from the project, and declared victory in 2011 when the firm lost its bid to develop a railway in Saudi Arabia, calling it a first step toward “kicking Alstom out of the Arab world”. A year later, though, the kingdom awarded it more than $1 billion worth of contracts to develop power plants—hardly a sign of a boycott. In 2016, a seemingly not-at-all-chastened Alstom accepted a $395 million offer to extend the light rail into yet another settlement in East Jerusalem.

And yet Israel continues to treat BDS as an existential threat. Politicians (and *Yediot Aharonot*) have declared “war” on it. The government has allocated $26 million to fight the movement, a figure that some lawmakers would like to increase exponentially. When Erdan took office in 2015, he said he accepted the job with a sense of “holy dread.” All of this for a campaign that, by one 2014 estimate, had caused about $30 million in